



The World Cup

More than just football?

One tournament stops the world every four years. Not everything it brings shows up on the scoreboard.



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Fans celebrate as the World Cup trophy is lifted in front of a packed stadium.

WARM-UP

Discuss the questions with a partner.

1. Think of a sporting moment you still remember. What made it matter beyond the result?
2. Is cheering for your national team patriotism? When does it become something else?

For ninety minutes, a nation can forget almost everything else. Streets empty, strangers embrace, and people who never watch football find themselves shouting at a screen. No other event gathers so much of humanity around a single game. Yet the World Cup has always been about more than football, and what exactly it is about depends on who is watching, and who is paying.

For a host country, the tournament is a chance to present itself to billions. Governments spend enormous sums on stadiums, transport, and security, hoping for tourism, investment, and national pride. Critics call this “sportswashing”: using the glamour of a global event to **paper over the cracks** at home, from the treatment of migrant workers to limits on free speech. The charge is hard to dismiss, though it is applied selectively; democratic hosts with controversies of their own rarely face the same criticism.

The economic case is shakier than it looks. Several hosts are left with near-empty stadiums, each a **white elephant** that taxpayers go on funding. Football’s governing body has repeatedly **come under scrutiny** over how hosting rights are awarded, amid corruption scandals at the very top. For fans, too, the tournament can be a **double-edged sword**: the passion that unites a country can turn ugly, spilling into nationalism.

And yet the unity is real. A diverse national team can make citizens who rarely agree **rally behind** a shared symbol, and a small nation’s unlikely victory can shape how its people see themselves for a generation. Some argue that sport should simply stay out of politics. Others reply that an event this large is always political; the only question is whose politics it serves.

Can a game that unites billions ever be truly neutral?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the expressions (1–5) with their meanings (A–E).

- | | | |
|--------------------------|-------|-----------------------------------|
| 1. a double-edged sword | _____ | A. to be examined critically |
| 2. rally behind | _____ | B. to unite in support of |
| 3. a white elephant | _____ | C. to hide problems, not fix them |
| 4. come under scrutiny | _____ | D. helpful and harmful at once |
| 5. paper over the cracks | _____ | E. a costly project of little use |

TRUE OR FALSE

Judge what the article states *or implies*. Circle T or F.

- | | | |
|---|----------|----------|
| 1. The writer finds sportswashing credible. | T | F |
| 2. Some hosts face harsher criticism. | T | F |
| 3. Hosting reliably pays off economically. | T | F |
| 4. The writer dismisses national unity. | T | F |
| 5. Fan passion has a darker side. | T | F |

DISCUSSION

- 1 Would you want your country to host the World Cup? What would worry you?
- 2 Can one tournament really change how a country is seen abroad?
- 3 Why might sportswashing criticism fall harder on some hosts than others?
- 4 Should players use the tournament to make political statements?
- 5 If a tournament leaves stadiums empty but a nation proud, was it worth it?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

KEEP POLITICS OUT?

The principle: “Sport and politics should be kept separate.”

Test it against each case. Does the principle give a clear answer? Then circle whether you would accept what happens.

CASE	CLEAR ANSWER?		ACCEPT IT?	
1 A captain wears a rainbow armband where it is banned.	Yes	No	Yes	No
2 A country at war is banned from the tournament.	Yes	No	Yes	No
3 Fans boo the other team’s national anthem.	Yes	No	Yes	No
4 A team refuses to play in a host it calls oppressive.	Yes	No	Yes	No
5 A state-owned oil company becomes chief sponsor.	Yes	No	Yes	No
6 The host bans all protests near the stadiums.	Yes	No	Yes	No

YOUR VERDICT Case that breaks the principle: No. _____ Your improved principle: _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Did the principle ever point both ways at once? In which case?
 - 2 Compare with another pair. Challenge one ruling that differs from yours.
 - 3 Is “keeping politics out” itself a political choice? Who benefits from it?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete each sentence with an expression from the box.
Change the form if you need to.

come under scrutiny a white elephant
paper over the cracks a double-edged sword
rally behind

- 1 Fame is _____ for young players.
- 2 The whole town _____ its local team.
- 3 The new airport is _____ nobody uses.
- 4 His expenses _____ after the leak.
- 5 A new logo can’t _____ in a failing firm.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

“Hosting the World Cup does a country more harm than good.” To what extent do you agree?

Write 200–250 words. Address the strongest opposing view before you answer it.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • PROPOSE • DEFEND

In small groups, build one position and hold it under pressure.

- | | |
|----------------|--|
| ROLE | You sit on the committee that chooses the next World Cup host. |
| PROPOSE | Set ONE condition every host must meet. Say which bids it would rule out. |
| DEFEND | Present in two minutes. A rejected bidder then calls it unfair. Answer them without abandoning your condition. |